

which could even be scenes from *Big Boss*. Television was feeding television and reality wasn't the same anymore. As actor Anupam Kher remarked: "The Liberhan Commission's media coverage has already overshadowed the first anniversary of 26/11. It speaks a lot about our sensitivity." Television channels also upped their role as conscience keepers and social activists, ensuring that Manu Sharma had to cut short his controversially gained parole and Ruchika Girhotra's death will not go unpunished. All very laudatory but again, desperately seeking audience share. Do-good TV was as good, or bad, as do-bad TV, as in invading privacy, chasing scandals and trivialising news. The race for ratings was putting an uncomfortable spotlight on the media rather than on the subjects of their scrutiny.

Yet, there was also much to be thankful for. Gays were out of the closets and everywhere else as the Delhi High Court junked a colonial law that criminalised gay sex—and indeed anything other than heterosexual vaginal intercourse—in India. Indeed, the judiciary showed that apart from getting proactive—questioning the proliferation of Mayawati statues for instance—it was getting increasingly progressive as well. The decision to reveal assets of judges was historic, even as one of their own, Justice Dinakaran, was in the dock and denied a seat at judiciary's high table for allegedly not revealing his assets. Finally, transparency in public life was

making itself visible, as the RTI Act forced a greater number of officials and politicians to make involuntary disclosures about sensitive issues like expenses and travel. National interest acquired a new definition, and not a year too soon. In many ways, it was a sign that Indian society was becoming increasingly mature. Maybe it was to do with the new breed of

Indians increasingly impatient for change and weary of status quo.

Ultimately, it was technology that dominated our lives and pockets. A BlackBerry in hand was as much about status as connectivity, as mobile sales in India crossed 510 million, 160 million in 2009 alone. Bill Gates had predicted this would be the digital decade and so it proved. As a reces-

sion-led relegation of the printed word saw front pages of national newspapers replaced by advertisements, how symbolic was that? Between twitter's pointless babble, social networks' ego massages, e-books and newspapers on Kindle, TV's eyeball-catching extremes and mobiles for the masses, 2009 was truly the year of the digerati. ■



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Cellphones became an essential distraction (top); Indian students protesting in Melbourne